

History lesson

The first high speed computer printer was used on a Univac computer and was developed by Remington-Rand in 1953

Cook while you surf

A USB microware has been created by Gama Microwave Technology and Heinz called the Beanzawave. This device once connected to your PC, doesn't really use microwaves, but instead, warms food using combinations of cellphone and radio frequencies.

Photo printer test

BEST BUY
digit
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Canon Pixma iP1980

rear via the document feeder, but here there is a major design flaw: there is no paper out tray. This means that printouts are bound to slide all over the place, and if the desk on which the printer is placed is too small, the paper will fall to the ground.

The print quality of the Pixma iP1980 is not that great. The overall outcome of the three test photos showed that the colours were on the warmer side and there was also some visible bands printed. The first test photo showed the end of the darker shades of black merging together in the greyscale chart included in the image. The ripples and reflections in the water do not look that good either. There is huge loss of details with this printout.

The second test image shows that this printer wasn't able to recreate some subtle details in the photo and was left with some dull and blended portions. The black wasn't really looking that black in the third test image due to the abundance of red tingeing throughout. Also in one scene in which there are purple pebbles in a fish bowl, these pebbles came out on the darker side and tended to merge with one another. Our Combi document showed the text to be sharp and readable, but at the same time the images were rather pixelated and the reds weren't reproduced correctly.

The eco-mode prints showed a clear difference in quality as

well as print speed, but the prints were very fuzzy and even the text showed jagged edges. There were also yellow bands visible when we printed out the test image number three in eco-mode. This clearly shows that the Canon Pixma iP1980 is

overall rather average, although it is priced at a very attractive Rs. 2,695.

Canon Pixma iP2680

The Pixma iP2680, as the name suggests, is also a photo inkjet printer from Canon and is in a different series from the iP1980. The design of the iP2680 is similar to that of the Pixma iP1980, but is more stylish with a black glossy exterior with a silver line, running horizontally, facing the front.

This printer also has only two buttons, one for power and the other to clear paper jams. There is also no network or PictBridge support with the Canon iP2680.

One much needed improvement over the iP1980



Canon Pixma iP2680

is the inclusion of a paper-out tray. This tray has to be pulled down to use and there is also an extension on the tray that you can swing into place so that the paper doesn't slide off. Paper is loaded from the rear document feeder and this printer can hold a maximum of 100 sheets of plain paper.

Setting up the printer is the same as with the iP1980. The two print cartridges the iP2680

uses, black and colour, are the same as that of the iP1980. The head alignment in this case is also a manual task in which you have to judge for yourself which box has the least lines.

The print quality of this Pixma is slightly better in the first two test photos than the iP1980, but overall the prints from this printer also had a warm tone. A little less banding, compared to the iP1980, was visible when we printed the first test image. The darker shades of black also merged together in the greyscale portion of the image. The print showed a slightly better effect of ripples, but overall it looked dull and there were many details missed.

The second test image also showed some banding, and some pixels in the image were visible, but not as much as with the iP1980. The third test print had an excess of red, to an extent that some black areas looked red and merged with an object behind them. Also some shadows on the object were not printed correctly and looked very artificial. The Combi document showed better results than the iP1980, as the images looked better and the reds were not merged as with the iP1980.

Eco-mode gave us similar results to those of the iP1980, with some yellow banding on the image and jagged edges on the text and very bad pixelation in the images of the Combi document.

The Canon Pixma iP2680 has not taken a huge step forward in terms of print quality. Moreover the speed at which this printer prints is almost the same as that of the iP1980. It certainly has a few design improvements, but paying Rs. 3,695 for it doesn't make much sense as it is still only average in print quality.

Canon Pixma iP4680

Finally, Canon shows its game face with its Pixma iP4680. This printer is good looking, and although there are design similarities to the iP1980 and iP2680, this printer offers more

in terms of connectivity and features.

The Pixma iP4680 sports a nice silver border along the top. It also comes with two buttons, but the position has been shifted from the top to the right side of the printer. One button is for power, while the other is to clear paper jams.

This Pixma comes with USB PictBridge support, something missing from both the iP1980 and iP2680. It also comes with a paper tray at the bottom, which is supposed to be used for normal paper. The rear document feeder is supposed to be used for photo print paper. We don't really see why Canon has opted to make this a bit more complicated. The bottom tray is tightly fitted and not really visible. Unfortunately, there is no display or additional properties that can be adjusted on this printer. Compared to the iP1980 and iP2680, this printer can hold 50 more sheets, a total of 150 sheets of A4-size plain paper. There is



Canon Pixma iP4680

also a CD tray with this printer, in which you can place CDs or DVDs in order to print images onto them directly. There is a slot above the paper-out extension where this CD tray has to be fitted.

Five print cartridges need to be loaded into the Pixma iP4680; these consist of CMYK colours along with a separate black cartridge. Installing these cartridges was very easy, as there is just a simple push and click mechanism involved. This printer automatically does a head alignment — all you have to do is load the paper for it to print the alignment sheet.

The overall print quality of the Pixma iP4680 gave a cooler tone compared to the warmer